

Tailwind Traders

Customer Returns Policy & Internal Handling Standard

Version 4.2 - effective 2026-04-01 - owner: Digital Customer Experience (E. Marsh) - internal + customer-facing extract

1. Customer promise

You can return most items within 30 days of delivery for a full refund. Outdoor and clothing items must be unworn with tags attached. For hygiene reasons, bedding, water bottles, socks and similar items can only be returned if unopened and the hygiene seal is intact. Faulty or dangerous items can be returned at any time and we cover return postage.

2. How a return is processed (internal standard)

Every returned item is handled by a contact-centre agent in ReturnDesk. The agent must, for each return:

- Read the customer's free-text reason and select the single best reason code from the taxonomy.
- Approve or decline the refund. All refunds require agent approval - there is no automatic refund.
- Assess for possible abuse (wardrobing, serial returns) using the customer's order history.
- Choose a disposition for the item: restock, refurbish, liquidate, or recycle.

Target turnaround is 2 working days from the item arriving at the warehouse to the refund being issued. Current average is 9 working days and rises sharply during the Black Friday and January peaks.

3. Reason codes

Agents must avoid the OTHER code wherever a specific code applies. OTHER currently accounts for 41% of returns, which leaves the business unable to analyse why products come back. The reason-code taxonomy is maintained by the Returns Team Lead and distributed as a separate workbook.

4. Disposition guidance

- Restock - unworn, resellable, tags/seal intact. Returns to sellable stock.
- Refurbish - minor clean, repackaging, or repair needed before resale.
- Liquidate - not resellable as new; sold to a clearance partner at reduced value.
- Recycle - unsafe, used hygiene items, or beyond economic repair. Destroyed responsibly.

Disposition is currently chosen by the agent from their desk without sight of the physical item. An internal audit found roughly 30% of dispositions were sub-optimal, either destroying resellable value or restocking items that should not have been resold.

5. Suspected returns abuse

Where an agent suspects wardrobing or serial-return abuse, the case should be marked for review rather than refused outright. Any decision affecting a customer must be explainable and evidenced from order history - customers may not be refused or flagged on the basis of an unexplained score. Finance estimates returns abuse at approximately GBP 2.3M per year, the large majority of which is not currently detected.

6. Data protection

Customer returns and purchase history are personal data under UK GDPR. Any profiling used to identify abuse must be fair, explainable, and retained only as long as necessary. Customers may request the reasons behind any decision affecting them.